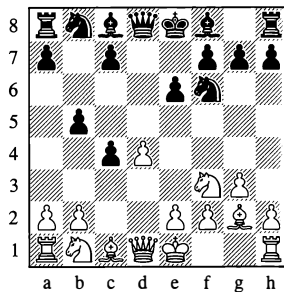




Catalan 4...dxc4



5...b5

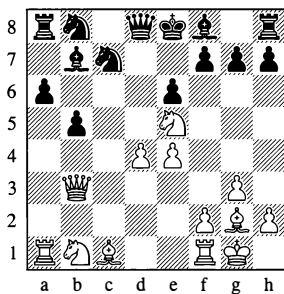
Variation Index

1.d4 ♖f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♗f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 b5

6.a4 c6 7.axb5 cxb5 8.♗e5 ♗d5 9.0-0! ♙b7 10.b3! cxb3 11.♙xb3 a6 12.e4

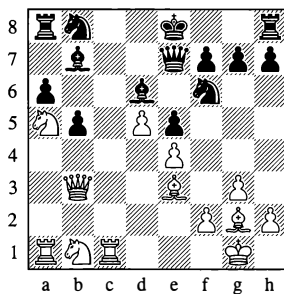
A) 12...♗f6 13.d5	129
A1) 13...♙d6	129
A2) 13...exd5	130
B) 12...♗b4N	131

note to move 12



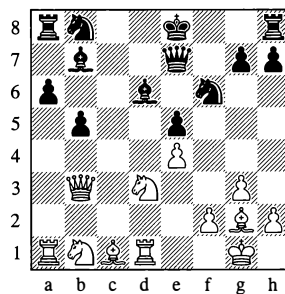
13.♙f3!N

A) note to move 13



18.♙g5N

A1) after 16...e5

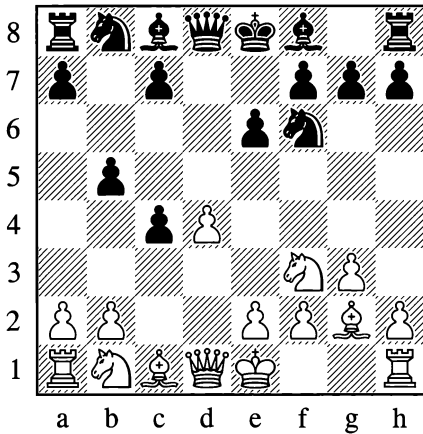


17.♗xe5!!

1.d4 ♖f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♗f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 8.♗e5 ♖d5
b5

Nothing could be more natural than Black's last move: he defends his extra pawn, planning later to complete development and convert his material advantage.

Of course matters are not that simple, and essentially the whole variation is known to be quite dangerous for Black: White's advantage in development allows him to seize the initiative in many lines.



6.a4

In my opinion this is the best move order.

6...c6

Obviously Black cannot play 6...♙b4†? due to 7.♙d2 ♙xd2† 8.♗fxd2! c6 9.axb5± with a clear advantage.

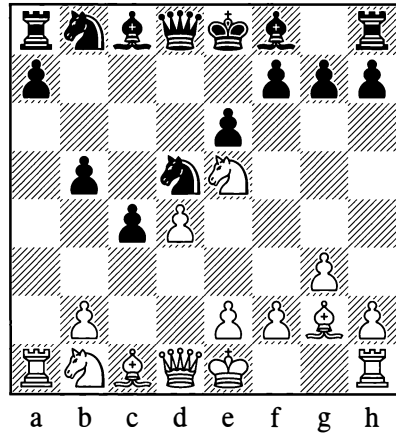
7.axb5

Once again this is the correct move order.

7.♗e5 allows Black 7...♙b4† (or even 7...♗d5 8.axb5 ♙b4†!N and after 9.♗c3 ♗xc3 10.bxc3 ♙xc3† 11.♙d2 ♗xd4 12.♗f3 ♙xd2† 13.♗xd2 c3 Black should easily hold the position) 8.♗c3 ♗d5, and this leads to a different line from the one I want.

7...cxb5

7...♙b4†? 8.♙d2 ♙xd2† 9.♗fxd2±



9.0-0!

This is a simple solution compared to the complex lines covered in *GM 1*. There are not many games in which this move has been played, so there is great scope for creativity.

9...♙b7

The only move which Black has chosen, but it was also important to check the alternatives:

After 9...♙e7 White easily develops an initiative by means of 10.♗c3 f6 11.e4!, when one illustrative line is: 11...♗xc3 12.♗h5† g6 13.♗xg6 ♗e2† 14.♗xe2 hxg6 15.e5! Unfortunately for Black this move gives White a decisive advantage. 15...♙d7 (15...♗xd4 16.exf6 ♗xf6 17.♙xa8+– is hopeless for Black) 16.♙xa8 ♗c6 17.♙b7!? ♗b6 18.♙xc6 ♗xc6 19.exf6 ♙xf6 20.♗g4± White is winning.

9...f6 runs into the same idea, but with a different execution: 10.e4 ♗e7 11.♗h5† g6 12.♗xg6 ♗xg6 13.e5 White has a huge advantage.

10.b3!

Before striking in the centre White activates his queen.

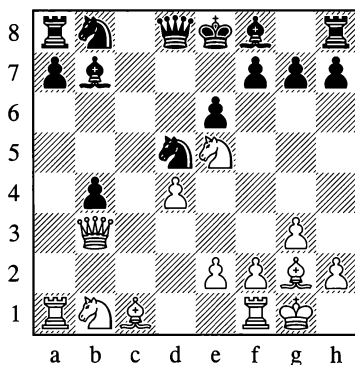
10...cxb3 11.♖xb3 a6

Black's only choice in practice.

I also checked a natural attempt to give the pawn back: 11...♘c6 12.♙xc6! (12.♖xb5 ♖b6 allows Black to simplify into a decent endgame after 13.♖xb6 axb6 14.♞xa8† ♙xa8) 12...♙xc6 13.e4 The following sample line shows how dangerous Black's position is: 13...♙b6 14.d5! exd5 15.exd5 ♙xd5 16.♖xb5† ♗d7 17.♙c3! ♖xb5 18.♙xb5 ♙xg2 19.♙xg2± The black king is horribly exposed.

11...b4

This runs into an elegant solution:

**12.♙c3!**

Now Black's lack of development begins to tell.

12...♙e7

Other moves are no better:

a) 12...a5 13.♖a4† ♙d7 14.♙xd5 ♙xd5 (14...exd5 15.♖b5 is even worse for Black) 15.e4 ♙b7 16.d5 ♙d6 17.♙xf7! ♙xf7 18.dxe6† ♙xe6 19.♖b3† ♙e7 20.♙g5† ♙f6 21.e5 ♙xe5 22.♞fe1 and White is winning.
b) 12...f6 13.♙xd5 ♙xd5 14.♖a4† ♙d7 15.e4 ♙b7 16.♙d3 ♙d6 (Black cannot hold the pawn with 16...a5, since 17.♙f4 ♞a6 18.d5! gives White a decisive initiative.) 17.♙f4 ♙e7 18.♙c5! Now White is not even interested in regaining the pawn immediately: 18...♙xc5

19.dxc5 ♖c8 20.♞fd1 ♙c6 21.♖xb4 e5 22.♙e3 0-0 23.♙h3 White has a huge advantage.

13.♖a4† ♙f8

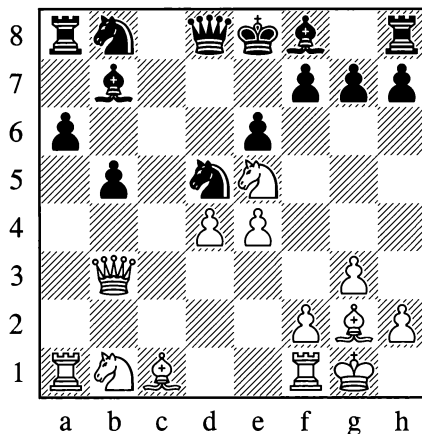
13...♙d7 14.♙xd5 ♙xd5 15.e4 ♙b7 16.d5! is pretty hopeless for Black.

14.♙xd5 ♙xd5 15.e4

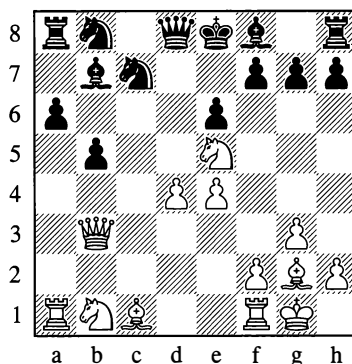
15.♙xd5 ♖xd5 16.♙d2 also looks good.

15...♙b7 16.d5

White has a clear advantage.

12.e4

At this point the most common move is A) 12...♙f6, but we must also consider B) 12...♙b4N.

12...♙c7**13.♖f3!N**

This is even more convincing than the continuation 13.d5 ♖d6 (13...♖d7 is also worthy of consideration) 14.♖c4! bxc4 15.♗xb7 0–0 16.♖d2, when after 16...exd5 17.exd5 ♖d7 18.♖xc4± White had regained his pawn and kept a pleasant advantage in Iskusnyh – Sarana, Samara 2013.

13...♗f6

13...♗e7 runs into 14.♙a3 b4 (14...♗f6 15.♗c3! ♗d8 16.♙c1 is winning for White) 15.♙xb4 ♗f6 16.♗b3± with a huge advantage.

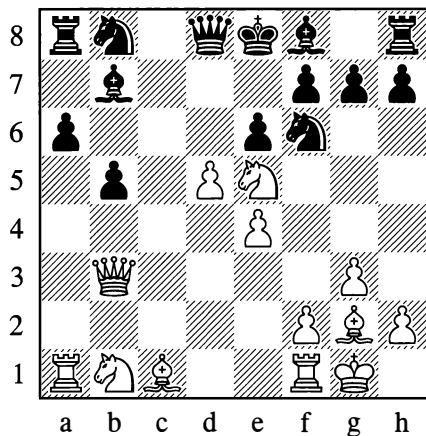
14.♙f4 ♖d6 15.♗h5! ♗e7

15...g6 16.♗h6 ♙f8 17.♗h3 looks horrible for Black.

16.♙g5 ♗f8 17.♙c1 ♙xe5 18.dxe5 ♖c6 19.♙a2!

Black will lose material when the white rooks double up on the c-file.

A) 12...♖f6 13.d5



We have reached another split, with Black's main continuations being A1) 13...♙d6 and A2) 13...exd5.

13...♖bd7N meets a simple yet elegant refutation: 14.♖xf7! ♖c5 15.♖xd8 ♖xb3 16.♖xb7 ♖xa1 17.dxe6 ♙c8 18.e5 ♖b3 19.♙b2 ♖g4 20.♖d6† ♙xd6 21.exd6+– Black will not be able to hold this.

13...♗b6 14.♖c4!

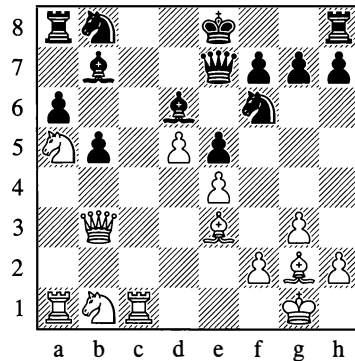
A nice idea, although White is also better after the natural 14.♙e3 ♙c5 15.dxe6.

14...♗c7

The main point behind White's idea is that 14...♗d4 runs into: 15.♖ba3! (less convincing is 15.♙a4 ♗c5 16.♖a5 ♙xd5 17.exd5 bxa4 18.♗b7 ♗xa5 19.♙f4 ♗d8 20.dxe6 fxe6 21.♗xa8 ♖bd7) 15...♗xa1 16.♙b2 ♗xf1† 17.♖xf1 White's deadly threat of ♖a5 give him a clear advantage.

15.♖a5 e5 16.♙e3 ♙d6 17.♙c1 ♗e7

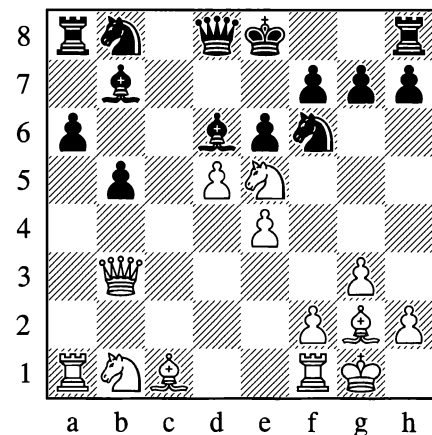
This happened in Agzamov – O. Foisor, Sochi 1985, and now the strongest continuation was:



18.♙g5N 0–0 19.♙h3!

Black can hardly move any of his pieces – White's advantage is decisive.

A1) 13...♙d6



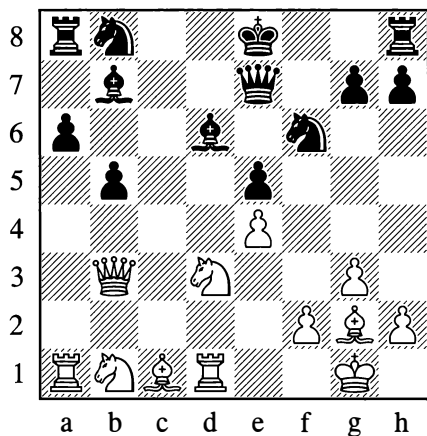
14.dxe6N

Surprisingly, this is even stronger than capturing on f7, thanks to an amusing idea on the 17th move.

It is admittedly hard to refrain from: 14.♟xf7 ♜xf7 15.dxe6† ♜e8 16.e5! (the main finesse of White's combination) 16...♙xg2 17.exf6 ♜xf6 18.♙xg2 ♜xa1 19.♜d5N (An improvement over 19.♙b2 ♜a4 20.♜f3 as in Giri – Morozevich, Beijing [rapid] 2012. White won quickly, but it seems like the astonishing 20...♜c2!!N may hold the game for Black.) 19...♜e5 20.♜xa8 ♜xe6 21.♟c3± Obviously White has a dangerous initiative, but Black has some defensive resources.

14...fxe6 15.♞d1 ♜e7 16.♟d3 e5

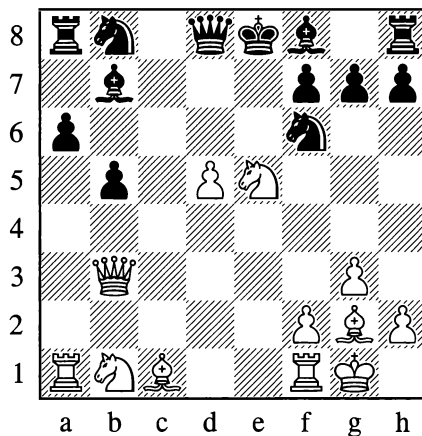
The last sequence was forced, but now a brilliant blow comes from nowhere:

**17.♟xe5!! ♙xe4**

White wins easily after 17...♙xe5 18.♙a3+– or 17...♜xe5 18.♙f4 ♜xa1 19.♙xd6+–.

18.♙xe4 ♟xe4 19.♞e1 ♜xe5 20.♟c3

It's curtains for Black.

A2) 13...exd5 14.exd5!**14...♙xd5**

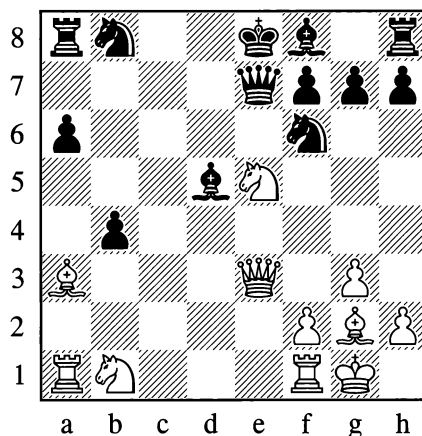
It transpires that Black cannot develop with 14...♙d6, as 15.♟c6 ♜c7 16.♞e1† ♟f8 17.♙a3 ♟bd7 18.♞c1+– leaves White with a decisive advantage.

15.♜e3 ♜e7

The only move, since 15...♙e7 loses to 16.♞d1.

16.♙a3 b4

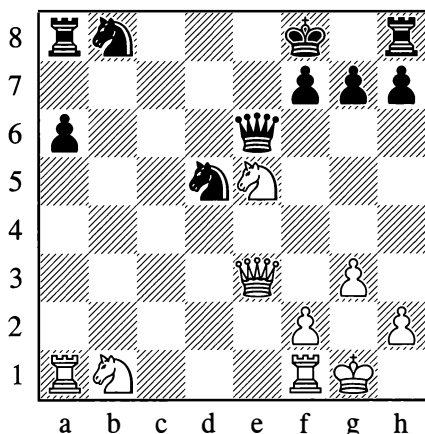
16...♜e6 17.♞e1 doesn't change a lot.

**17.♙xb4 ♜e6**

White's next sequence of moves comes naturally:

18. ♖xf8 ♜xf8 19. ♖xd5 ♜xd5

19... ♖xd5 20. ♜c3 only helps White.

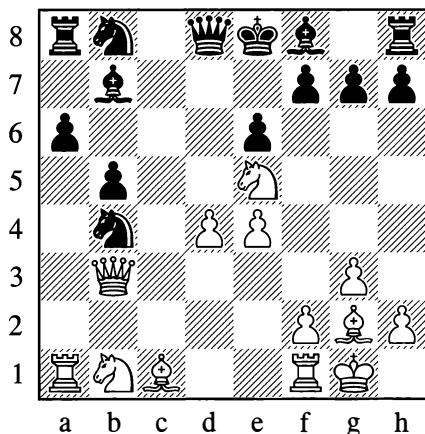


**20. ♖c5† ♜e7 21. ♖e1 ♜bc6 22. ♜c3 ♜xe5
23. ♖xe5 ♖c8 24. ♖a5+–**

Black cannot hold such a position for long.

B) 12... ♜b4N

According to my engine this is the best square for the black knight.

**13.d5!**

This central break is an obligatory move for White in this line.

13...exd5

There are two important alternatives to consider:

13... ♖d6 runs into a familiar theme: 14. ♜xf7! ♜xf7 15. dxe6† ♜e8 Now the most convincing is 16. ♜c3 ♜8c6 17. ♖d1 ♖c7 18. e5 ♜xe5 19. ♖xd6 ♖xd6 20. ♖xb7 ♖b8 21. ♖g2+ with a large advantage to White.

13...f6 14. ♜g4!

At first I was excited about 14. ♖f3 fxe5 15. ♖h5†, but somehow after 15... ♜d7 16. dxe6† ♜c7 17. ♖xe5† ♜c8 things become less clear.

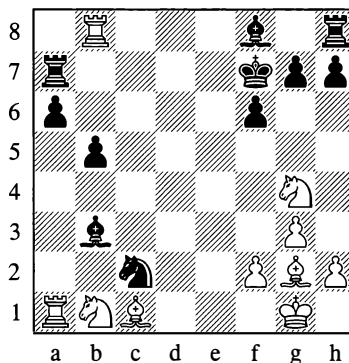
14...exd5

After 14...e5 15. ♜a3! Black has a hard time stopping White's ♖d2 idea. 15... ♜d7 16. ♖d1! White can even afford to not rush with ♖d2; after 16... ♖c5 17. ♖d2 a5 18. d6! White has a huge advantage.

14... ♖c8 (with the idea of ... ♖c4) is easy to parry with 15. ♜a3. Now 15...exd5 16. exd5 ♖xg4 doesn't really work for Black as 17. ♖e1† ♜d8 18. ♖e3! wins on the spot for White.

15. exd5 ♖xd5 16. ♖e1† ♜f7

16... ♖e7 is impossible in view of 17. ♖xb4.

17. ♖d1 ♖xb3 18. ♖xd8 ♖a7 19. ♖xb8 ♜c2**20. ♖a5!**

The only square for the rook, but it is enough to retain an advantage. An important line is as follows:

20... ♖d7 21. ♜d2 ♜d4 22. ♜xb3 ♜xb3 23. ♖xa6 ♖d1† 24. ♖f1 ♖xc1 25. ♖a7† ♜g6 26. ♜g2+

Black has regained his piece, but White is clearly better.

14.exd5 ♖d6

14...♙xd5

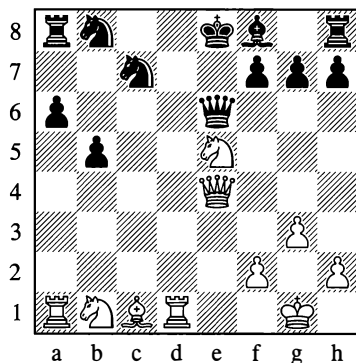
The only worthwhile alternative, although Black will find it surprisingly difficult to solve all his problems:

15.♙e3 ♙e7

15...♞c2 16.♙e2 ♞d4 17.♙h5! ♞a7 (or 17...g6 18.♞xg6 hxg6 19.♞e1+ ♞e6 20.♙xh8 ♙xg2 21.♙a3 ♞d7 22.♙xf8 ♞dxf8 23.♞xg2 and Black does not enough for the exchange) 18.♙xd5 ♙xd5 19.♞c3 ♙c5 20.♞e1! ♙xc3 21.♙e3 and Black is helpless against White's crushing attack.

16.♙xd5 ♞xd5 17.♙e4 ♙e6 18.♞d1 ♞c7

The last sequence has been fairly logical, but now comes the key move:



19.♞a2! ♙e7

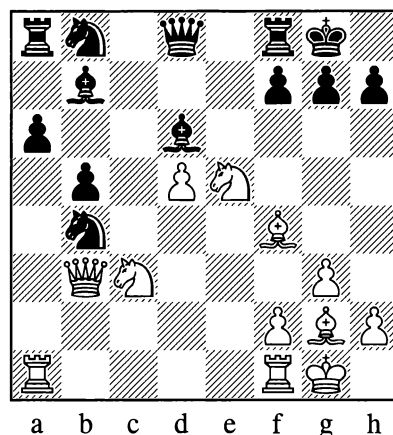
19...♙d6 loses to 20.♞ad2.

20.♞c2 0-0 21.♞xc7 ♙d6 22.♙xa8 ♙xc7 23.♞f3±

White should convert his material advantage.

15.♙f4 0-0 16.♞c3

Even though he has managed to castle, Black is still some way from overcoming his difficulties.



16...a5

A logical attempt to keep the knight protected on b4. I also checked some other possibilities:

16...♞e8 17.♞c6! ♞8xc6 18.dxc6 ♞xc6 19.♞fd1 and Black is unable to avoid material losses, for instance 19...♞e6 20.♞e4±.

16...♙b6 17.♞ad1

Black has an unpleasant choice here; to either give up his dark-squared bishop or to allow ♞c6.

17...♙xe5

17...a5 18.♙e3 ♙a6 (after 18...♙c5 19.♞e4! ♙xe3 20.fxe3 the open f-file only helps to increase White's initiative) 19.♞c6 ♞d7 20.♞e4 ♙c7 21.♞e7+ ♞h8 22.d6 ♙b6 23.♞g5 With a decisive initiative.

18.♙xe5 a5 19.♙d4 ♙a6

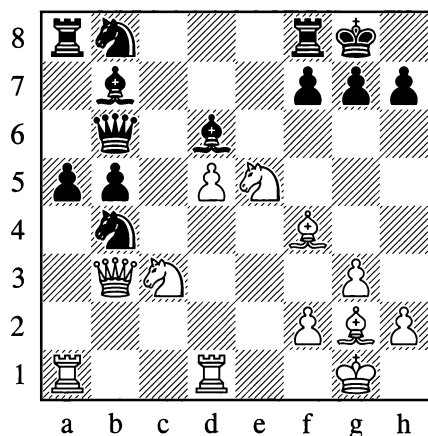
Or 19...♙g6 20.♞xb5 ♞8a6 21.♞c3 and, having regained the pawn, White has a comfortable positional advantage thanks to his bishop pair and strong passed pawn.

20.♞fe1 ♞d7 21.♞e7 ♞ad8 22.♞de1

White has more than sufficient compensation for a pawn.

17.♞fd1 ♙b6

17...♙xe5 18.♙xe5 ♞e8 19.♙f4± offers Black no relief.



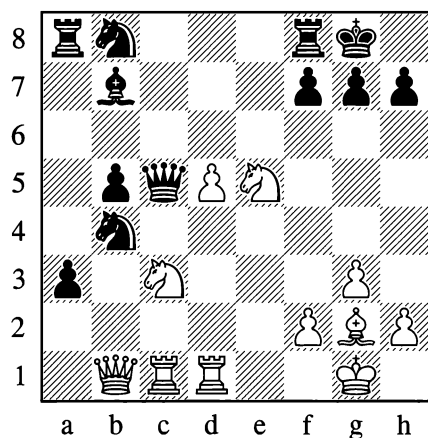
18. ♖e3 ♖c5

18... ♗a6 19. ♘c6 is just bad for Black.

19. ♘xc5 ♗xc5 20. ♖a1

White has full compensation for the pawn, with the only question being whether or not Black can hold the position. One important line runs as follows:

20...a4 21. ♗b1 a3



22. ♘g4!

The idea of ♘e4 is almost terminal for Black.

Conclusion

After 5...b5 6.a4 c6 7.axb5 cxb5 8.♘e5 ♘d5 I have decided to now recommend 9.0–0. This move has not been played often, which gave me the chance to include many fresh ideas. 9...♙b7 10.b3! is an important follow-up – activating the white queen. Then 10...cxb3 11.♗xb3 a6 12.e4 ♘b4N seems like the critical test, but White stands well in my main line. There are some wonderful attacking themes in this chapter, which I hope the reader will thoroughly enjoy.